

Banana Bread

Roast the bananas to concentrate them. Brown the butter for nutty Maillard depth. Trust the bicarbonate of soda — it neutralises the fruit's acid and browns the crust.

Yield: **2 loaves** (23×13 cm) Active: **25 min** Total: **2 hr** (incl. roast + cool) Oven: **175°C** (350°F) Done: **95°C** internal

WHERE IT WAS BORN

1930s United States. The Depression made a black banana too precious to bin; cheap new bicarbonate of soda made a *quick bread* possible. First printed in Pillsbury's *Balanced Recipes*, 1933.

EATEN, AUTHENTICALLY

A home loaf, sliced thick with butter or toasted — best on days two and three. Spread the length of US, then Caribbean and UK home kitchens.

HOW IT'S USED NOW

A cafe and galley staple worldwide; the same batter bakes into muffins (below). Note: today's *Cavendish* replaced the lost *Gros Michel*.

INGREDIENTS

WEIGHT ONLY · BAKER'S % / VOLUME IN RIGHT COLUMN

DRY		
Plain flour (<i>spoon & level</i>)	480g	· 100%
Bicarbonate of soda (<i>fresh</i>)	12g	· 2.5%
Fine sea salt	8g	· 1.7%
Cinnamon (<i>optional</i>)	4g	· 2 tsp

BROWN BUTTER, SUGAR & MISO

Unsalted butter (~200g <i>browned</i>)	230g	· 48%
Light brown sugar	300g	· 63%
Caster sugar	100g	· 21%
White (shiro) miso (<i>white only</i>)	60g	· 4 tbsp

WET & BANANA

Large eggs (<i>room temp</i>)	×	4
Vanilla extract (<i>real</i>)	20g	· 4 tsp
Greek yoghurt (<i>full-fat</i>)	120g	· ½ cup
Very ripe bananas (→~680g <i>roasted</i>)	900g	· ~8

THE RATIO — FLOUR = 100%
Flour 100 · banana 142 · sugar 83 · fat 42 · egg 42 · soda 2.5. Banana outweighs the flour — concentrate it by roasting and the crumb stays tender, not gummy.

Kit: 2 × 23×13 cm (9×5") loaf tins · light-coloured saucepan · scale · instant-read probe · parchment slings.

METHOD

- 1. Roast the bananas whole.** 150°C (300°F), unpeeled, on a lined tray, until skins are **black** and flesh jammy, 25–30 min. Cool, peel, discard pooled liquid — ~680g flesh.

Drives off ~25% of the banana's water + caramelises sugars → concentrated flavour, no gummy crumb. — Stella Parks, Serious Eats 2017

2. Fold, divide, bake. Whisk dry; fold into the wet (below) in two goes to **just combined** — flour streaks fine. Into 2 lined tins. **175°C (350°F), 50–60 min**, tent at 45 min if dark.

Soda hits the banana's acid and releases gas at once — get it to the oven; overmixing tightens the crumb. — McGee 2004

Brown butter, sugars & wet

- a.** Melt 230g butter in a *light* pan, swirling, until milk solids turn golden-brown + smell of hazelnut, 6–8 min. Off heat at once; scrape every fleck out. — *Maillard*, McGee 2004

b. Whisk in 300g brown sugar, 100g caster, 60g white miso while warm, 2 min. *Miso glutamates amplify sweetness — undetectable at this dose.* — *ChefSteps* 2018

c. Beat in 4 eggs one at a time, then 20g vanilla + 120g yoghurt.

d. Mash the roasted banana roughly (lumps welcome) and stir through. Now fold in the dry mix.

Done: Centre **95°C** (203°F); skewer with moist crumbs, not wet batter. Top domed, cracked, deep golden — colour alone lies, trust the probe.
Serve: cool in tin 15 min, lift out, cool 30 min before slicing. Best on days two and three. Freeze sliced, never the raw batter.

ONE BATTER, TWO BAKES — BANANA MUFFINS

The same batter is ~24 muffins. Line a tray, fill each well **two-thirds**; bake **175°C (350°F), 22–25 min** to the same 95°C centre. Demerara on top for a crackled lid. *More surface per gram = faster browning, more edges.*

ELEVATION

TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME Espresso powder — 1 tsp in the dry mix, deepens banana Dark brown sugar — swap 1:1, more molasses Sour cream for yoghurt — richer, denser	TIER 2 — WORTH IT Tahini swirl — 3 tbsp dragged across the top Miso–BB glaze — 2 tbsp BB + 1 tbsp miso + icing sugar Caribbean turn — rum raisins, lime zest, allspice	TIER 3 — RESTAURANT Brown-butter streusel — rubbed crumbs, scattered on top Brûléed slice — sugar + torch, to order Banana powder — freeze-dried, over warm slices
--	--	--

TROUBLESHOOT

Dense, tough	Overmixed or too much flour. Fold to just-combined; weigh flour.
Gummy band	Banana water. Roast it; pour off pooled liquid before mashing.
Sunken middle	Under-baked or too wet. Bake to a true 95°C internal.
Pale & sour	Too little soda or oven cool. Weigh soda; verify 175°C.
Soapy, metallic	Too much soda. Measure it — banana acid neutralises only so much.
Sticks to tin	No sling. Parchment with overhang lifts clean.

CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

The make-ahead	Roast banana in bulk; the loaf is then a 25-min job.
Roasted banana	Mash warm, 340g bags, freeze flat 3 mo. Thaw overnight, fridge.
Dry mix	Airtight, RT, 1 mo. Brown butter: fridge 2 wk, re-melt.
Baked, sliced	Wrap/seal, freeze 3 mo. Toast from frozen or 10 min / 150°C.
Hold	Wrapped at RT — better on days 2–3 than day one.
Never	Freeze the raw batter — soda dies; the loaf sits flat.